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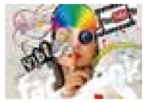

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# BATTLE OF THE BOARDS

**AMD's mid-range B550 motherboards offer the PCIe 4.0 speeds without breaking the bank. We take a look at the top boards from ASUS, GIGABYTE and MSI.**

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AMD's Ryzen 3000 processors have been a massive hit in the market and for a long while folks who wanted to build a rig with the Ryzen 3000 series had to resort to either the older X470, B450 and A320 motherboards or the more expensive X570 motherboards with their ridiculous power consumption thanks to the introduction of PCIe 4.0. Usually, all chipsets are available around launch but it would seem that AMD wanted to give board partners plenty of time to mint money with the X570 motherboards. Had the B550 and A520 chipsets been introduced earlier, the X570 boards wouldn't have sold as much as they have.

## B550 VS X570

With the introduction of the AMD B550 chipset, PC enthusiasts have the option of getting PCIe 4.0 without paying the ridiculous premium that X570 boards demand. However, there's a caveat here. Not all PCIe lanes are PCIe 4.0, only the ones coming out of the CPU are PCIe 4.0. Everything coming from the chipset is PCIe 3.0 and thus, the PCH power consumption is a manageable 5W instead of the 10W on X570 motherboards. This is the reason why we don't see B550 motherboards with a chipset fan. Another difference is that the X570 boards were SLI certified whereas the B550 boards aren't unless the manufacturer chose to do so. Certification costs money and by saving on SLI certification, the customer can get B550 boards for less than X570 boards.

One would assume that all 500 series chipsets would support the same set of processors but that isn't the case. The X570 boards supported 2nd Gen (Zen+) Ryzen and Ryzen-G processors along with the 3rd Gen (Zen2) Ryzen and future (Zen3) Ryzen processors. B550 and A520 drop support for Zen+ processors. So far, X470 and B450 boards are the only ones that support the entire lineup of Ryzen processors launched until now. That's three generations out of the box and possibly a 4th gen with BIOS updates for select boards. We could expect B550 boards to go the same way and support three generations of Ryzen processors.